



tried & tested
speaker test

For Your

EARS
Only

Your computer wants to tell you something. Turn up the volume...

Michael Browne

The last time we tested PC speakers was a year ago. Unlike most product categories where there is always something new (read *hot*) to report about, speaker gossip is out-of-stock at the moment. In fact, if our observations are true — computer speakers are slowly going the way of the Dodo. The reason — attrition of sorts is at work here. The falling prices of home-theatre setups, the availability of large-screen displays and cheap DVD players and even the preference for headphones, in general, over speakers, have all exacted their pound of flesh from the speakers' market. From what most distributors tell us, speaker sales are slowly dwindling and while it's too early to comment, we kind of agree with the facts.

The slowdown in the adoption of PC speakers has also affected manufacturers. This is clearly evident as we have fewer new models in the market today and the ones that are new are largely for the value-conscious segment. Gone are the days of the large eight-inch subwoofer drivers and the powerful four-inch mid-range drivers. Manufacturers are outfitting so-called subwoofers with puny four-inch drivers which we feel are not even capable of delivering 50 hertz, let alone anything lower than that. It seems like the spark has gone out of the market in the past couple of years. Gone are the nifty innovations that we used to see like optical connects, wireless speakers and the speakers themselves in general are not as powerful as PC speakers used to be. That's not to say this year's bunch of speakers were lack-lustre in any way. It's more like the market emphasis is shifting from performance to value-for-money — a fitting pre-recessionary trend; but one that we hope will change nonetheless — it's so much more fun that way.